THE BATTLE OF MIDWAY

In June 1942 Japan embarked upon an invasion of the American-held Midway atoll. One of the objectives was to draw the US Pacific Fleet into a decisive battle that Japanese commanders were confident they would win. Admiral Yamamoto dispersed his forces in a complex plan to distract and envelop his adversaries. Since the Americans had broken Japanese naval codes they were aware of Yamamoto's intentions and, ignoring a diversionary attack on the Aleutians, concentrated their efforts against Vice-Admiral Nagumo's force of four carriers. US Admiral Chester Nimitz sent two carrier task forces to defend Midway. Rear Admiral Fletcher commanded Task Force 16 with the carriers *Enterprise* and *Hornet*, while Rear Admiral Raymond Spruance led Task Force 17 with *Yorktown*, repaired at Pearl Harbor in a mere three days after its battering at the Coral Sea.

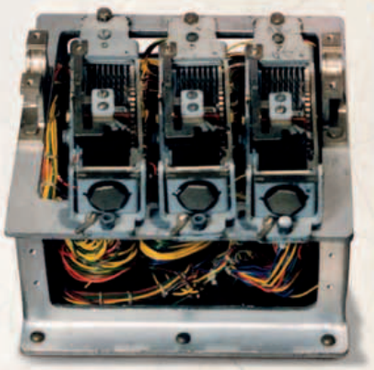
DECISIVE AIR STRIKES

Battle was joined on June 4. Unaware of the proximity of the US carriers, Nagumo launched an early morning air strike on Midway. He was planning a follow-up when a reconnaissance aircraft reported sighting enemy ships, tardily identified as including carriers. By then the Americans had already flown off their aircraft. Launched in haste and some confusion, the Wildcat fighters, Dauntless dive-bombers, and Devastator torpedo-bombers from *Hornet* and *Enterprise* searched for the enemy in uncoordinated groups. Unfortunately the slow-moving torpedo-bombers were first to locate Nagumo's carriers. Without fighter cover, they were pounced upon by Zero fighters. Not one of *Hornet's* 15 Devastators survived.

Aircraft from *Yorktown*, launched later than those from the other two carriers, arrived together at around 10:20 a.m. By chance, two squadrons of dive-bombers from *Enterprise* found Nagumo's force at the same moment. While *Yorktown's* Wildcats took on the Zeros, dive-bombers from *Yorktown* and *Enterprise* were left free to attack the carriers. Bomb after bomb struck the decks of Japanese carriers packed with aircraft, munitions, and fuel lines. In five minutes *Akagi*, *Kaga,* and *Soryu* were all burning wrecks.

The Japanese still had one carrier intact. *Hiryu* flew waves of bombers to deliver a counter-strike against *Yorktown*. Showing great determination in the face of American fighters and anti-aircraft fire, the Japanese pilots inflicted crippling damage upon the carrier. It was small compensation for a day of disaster for the Imperial Japanese Navy, capped late on when *Hiryu* was destroyed by dive-bombers from *Enterprise*.

Over the following days American aircraft and submarines harassed the withdrawing Japanese fleet, sinking the cruiser *Mikuma*. Meanwhile, efforts were made to salvage *Yorktown*, until a Japanese submarine hit the carrier with two torpedoes, also sinking a destroyer alongside. But nothing could detract from the scale of the American victory. That the invasion of Midway had been defeated was a minor point compared with the blow inflicted upon Japan's naval aviation. The loss of four carriers and many of their best naval pilots was a setback from which the Imperial Navy never recovered.



Purple encoding machine
The Americans never captured the Japanese "Purple" encoding machine, but Japanese naval code was understood well enough to warn the US Navy of the attack on Midway.



WORLD WAR II

BATTLE OF MIDWAY

Date	June 4–7, 1942
Location	Pacific Ocean near Midway Island
Result	American victory

COMBATANTS

UNITED STATES	JAPAN

COMMANDERS

Chester Nimitz, Frank Fletcher, Raymond Spruance	**Isoroku Yamamoto, Chuichi Nagumo**

FORCES

Ships: 3 carriers, 8 cruisers, 15 destroyers **Aircraft:** 233 carrier-based, 127 land-based	**Ships**: 4 carriers, 9 battleships, 6 cruisers, 25 destroyers **Aircraft:** 248

LOSSES

Men: 307 **Ships**: 1 carrier, 1 destroyer **Aircraft**: 98	**Men**: 3,057 **Ships**: 4 carriers, 1 cruiser **Aircraft**: 228

KEY

US FLEET
Cruisers, destroyers, and smaller ships in US carrier task forces not shown.

1 US aircraft carrier

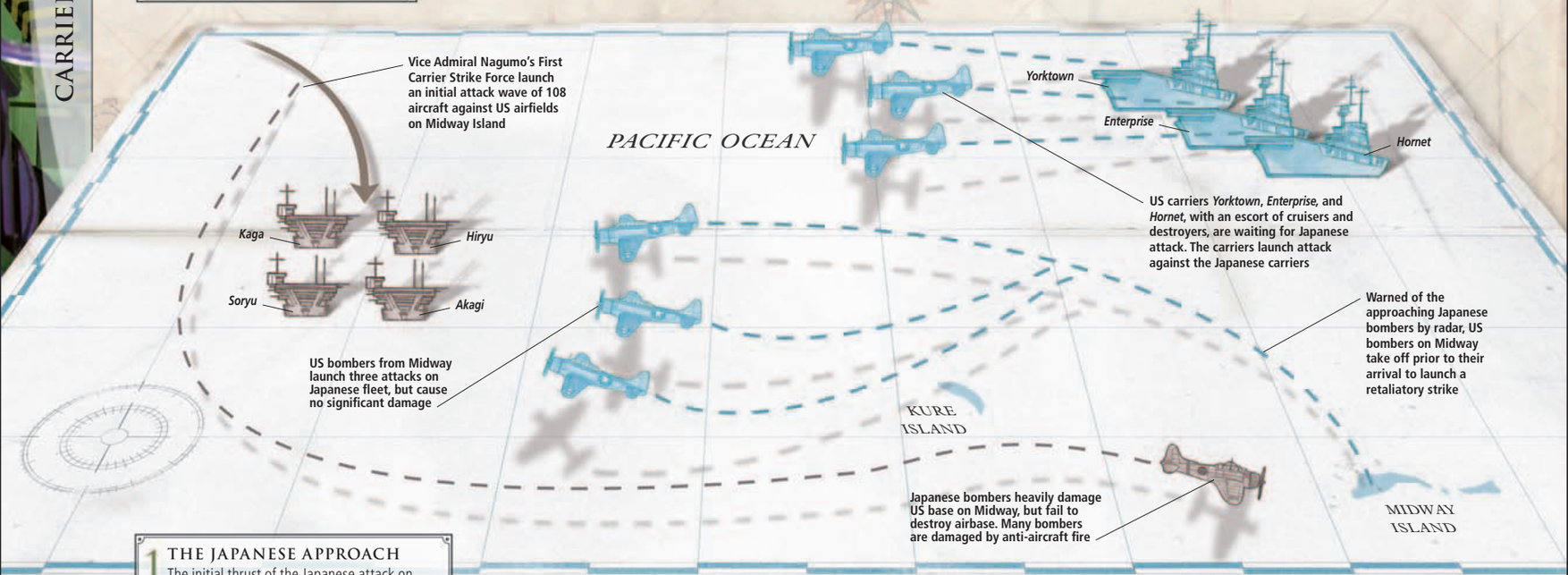
Wave of US bomber aircraft

JAPANESE FLEET
Cruisers, destroyers, and smaller ships in Nagumo's carrier strike force not shown. Main Japanese invasion force is off area of map.

1 Japanese aircraft carrier

Wave of Japanese bomber aircraft

1 Japanese cruiser



1 THE JAPANESE APPROACH
The initial thrust of the Japanese attack on Midway comes from Vice Admiral Nagumo's carrier strike force. Warned of the Japanese approach, two US carrier task forces are laying in wait and launch retaliatory air strikes against the Japanese carriers.